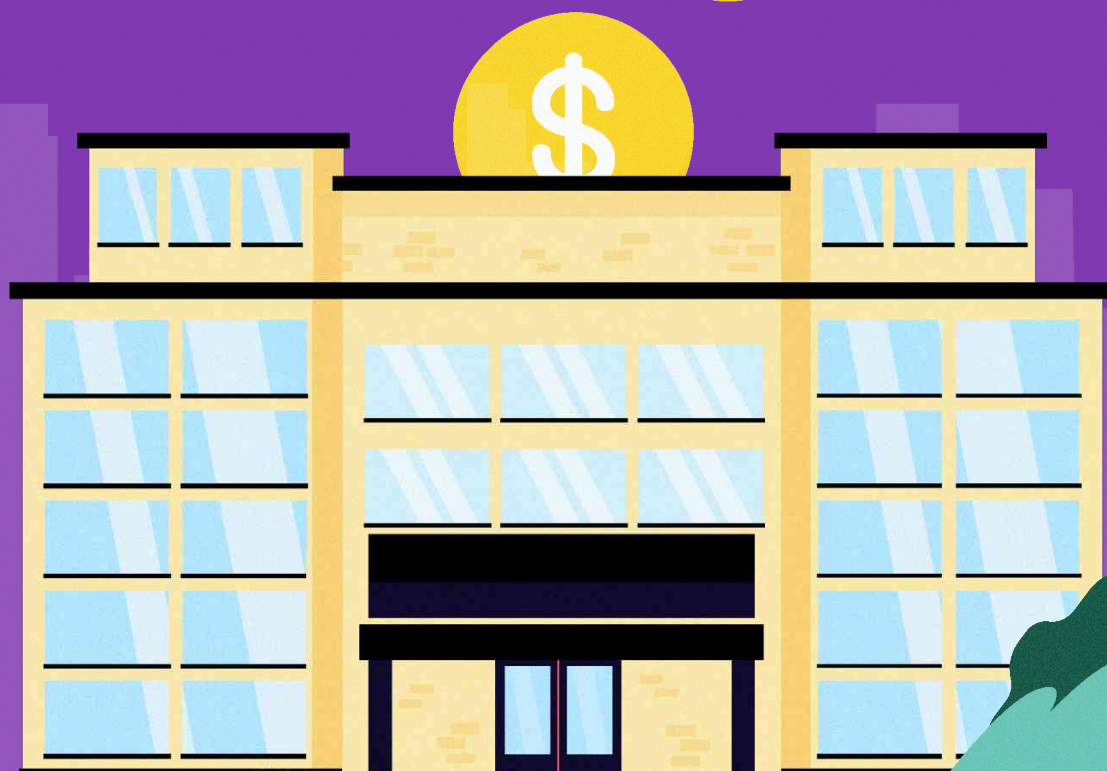




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ADDRESSING THE FUNDING GAP – HOW AFRICAN GOVERNMENTS CAN BUILD RESILIENCE TO FINANCE EDUCATION IN EMERGENCIES



1.0 BACKGROUND

The outbreak of the COVID-19 pandemic has only exposed and worsened the situation for millions of children and educational institutions on the continent. According to UNESCO's Global Education Report (2019), 258 million children and youth were entirely excluded from education with poverty as the main obstacle to access, with girls and the disabled being the most vulnerable.

The recent Global Education Summit saw Global Partnership for Education partners committing to raise their annual total public expenditure on education to 20% over the next five years to bridge the funding gap. However, questions have been raised as to whether this action is sufficient to curb the pertinent problems to ensure that the education we want is achieved amidst emergencies.

Education plays a key role in helping children, families, communities, and countries find a way out of conflict and crisis and usher progress in pursuit of prosperity. Education has an inherent value as a key element in ending the pervasive nature of poverty in the global world as outlined in the Sustainable Development Goals. However, crisis events and times of emergencies have overburdened governments with increasing costs of facilitating accessible and quality education in their states. This is particularly applicable for developing countries or majority of countries in the global south ¹.

In many countries within the sub-Saharan region, education is provided extensively by the public sector and is mostly focused on lower levels. Addressing major funding gaps in education is critical to improving access to and quality of education in Sub-Saharan Africa. However, despite the progress made in Africa's education sector, the continent has experienced several deficiencies in its educational sector. Most African governments have a common challenge of providing inclusive, accessible, and affordable education for all due to reasons such as inadequate funding, widening economic gap and marginalization of certain groups. ² These factors have constantly limited access to education for so many children and have deprived many children of their ability to pursue their dreams and aspirations. This reinforces the need to enact appropriate policies that would enhance the generation of both internal and external funds required for sustained progress in Africa's educational sector. According to UNESCO, there are three options for policymakers to explore to the finance education - public resources, external aid, and innovative funding. This brief paper analyses the approaches to financing education in Africa.



¹ Rafols, I., Ciarli, T., & Chavarro, D. (2015). Under-reporting research relevant to local needs in the global south. Database biases in the representation of knowledge on rice.

² <https://news.fundsfornongos.org/africa/africa-covid-19-unesco-urges-action-to-meet-funding-gap-for-education/>

2.0 COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS OF EDUCATION FINANCING IN AFRICA



Africa is a continent with peculiar challenges. It is also important to note that Africa experienced sustained levels of economic growth, with GDP rising at an average of 4.3 percent from 2000 to 2015. However, this did not directly translate into sufficient financing for education on the continent. This may be attributed to the plethora of development goals such as the Agenda 2063 that African countries have at the same time.

It is also impossible to downplay efforts at education investment in any country. Already, there are several initiatives for effective education financing, at both regional and global levels. These initiatives may not necessarily apply to each African country, owing to the complexities at the local of each distinct country. There are distinct levels of concern in relation to the provision of sustainable education investments, accessibility rates, and the diverse groups of students for inclusion at all levels.

In countries like Guinea, Mali, Rwanda and Zambia, foreign aid accounts for about 50% of government education budgets ⁴. However, in these regions, such foreign aids account for a smaller fraction of education investments which is only 5.6%. Statistics have also shown that Sub-Saharan Africa spends about 5% of its GDP on education. In comparison with North America and Europe (at 5.3%), the African continent seems to be doing well to ensure that good investments are made in public education ⁵. Yet, the majority of out-of-school children can be found in Africa ⁶. In trying to identify the best approaches to education financing in Africa, it is preferable to understand the context and what obstacles exist.

3.0 EDUCATION AS A PUBLIC GOOD

The outbreak of the COVID-19 pandemic exposed the loopholes in the education system, especially in funding for infrastructure and setting up new educational spaces to meet the abrupt changes the pandemic brought to many countries in Africa. Many public schools from the basic to the secondary shut down for almost a year without providing any efficient alternative to learning. The higher educational institutions which opted for the virtual model of learning faced major challenges such as the availability of internet connectivity for students in their places of residence, the availability of IT tools for learning, and the cost of internet data which many could not afford. The priority of governments during the pandemic was to ensure the safety of their citizens. This resulted in a cut in expenses for various sectors including education leaving it disrupted. The private sector was already ahead of the curve as most were already using the online modes of learning. The tuition in these schools, however, could only be afforded by the rich displaying the inequality gap between the rich and the poor.

The concept of education as a public good could be determined based on considerations about the existence of conditions for state intervention.⁷ Intervention from the State, however, must be defined in terms of provision, financing, or regulation of education opportunities from an economic and political perspective. If education were privatized, control would be left to individuals, acting through market mechanisms. However, to ensure that no one is left behind and equal access is granted to all, there is the need for African governments to re-define policies on education and consider education as a priority when allocating funds for development.

³ <http://www.iiep.unesco.org/en/financing-education-africa>

⁴ <https://www.theguardian.com/news/datablog/2011/apr/27/africa-education-spending-aid-data>

⁵ <https://www.theguardian.com/news/datablog/2011/apr/27/africa-education-spending-aid-data>

⁶ <https://www.theguardian.com/news/datablog/2011/apr/27/africa-education-spending-aid-data>

⁷ <https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000261614#:~:text=It%20has%20been%20argued%20that,is%20provided%2C%20funded%20and%20monitored.>

4.0 POLICY RECOMMENDATIONS

African governments have an important function in funding and providing educational opportunities especially in places of rampant inequality where children and the young people are at the risk of exclusion and discrimination. Therefore, it is imperative that the States act on the following recommendations:

- 1.** The main objective of African governments in financing education should not only focus on mobilizing resources but also on improving the effectiveness of the funding. Governments must ensure effective management of resources allocated to each sector, especially the education sector. As the resources are scarce, resources must be used for rightly intended purposes and this leads to our next recommendation of monitoring to ensure transparency and accountability.
- 2.** The role of the state should be strengthened particularly with regard to its regulatory and monitoring functions. It is necessary for states to adopt a monitoring mechanism to ensure that there is transparency and accountability on the part of providers of education. The State must ensure compliance at all levels in the educational sector especially in the private sector. It is also essential to develop new approaches which will integrate the notion of education as a public good with the fundamental social and cultural components of education which are often disregarded within standardized approaches, and also consider education as part of the domain of the public where transparent and participatory processes can take place.
- 3.** Education is a priority as much as health and other sectors of the economy. Governments must re-look at its priority areas and allocate funds proportionally. There is the need to bring balance in the allocation of resources to ensure one sector is not left deficient. Governments must also set aside emergency funds for future use wherever an emergency may arise. This will help to reduce the disruptions of in any sector when an emergency arises.





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